

Understanding Threat Landscape

SOC analysts must understand **who attackers are, why they attack, and how they do it:**

- **Attackers (Who?):**
 - Hacktivists (political/activist motives)
 - Cyber criminals (financial gain, ransomware, fraud)
 - Nation-state actors (cyber warfare, espionage)
 - Insider threats (disgruntled employees)
- **Motives (Why?):**
 - Stealing money or data
 - Damaging reputation
 - Espionage (spying)
 - Fun or challenge (script kiddies)
- **Techniques (How?):**
 - Phishing emails
 - Malware (ransomware, trojans, spyware)
 - Denial of Service (DoS/DDoS)
 - Exploiting vulnerabilities
 - Social engineering

👉 **Example:** A phishing email pretending to be a bank → attacker's motive is to steal money → technique used = social engineering.

Threat vs Threat Actor

1. Threat

- A **threat** is any **potential danger** that can harm an organization's systems, data, or network.
- It can be:
 - A **cyber attack** (like phishing or ransomware)
 - A **natural disaster** (like flood, earthquake affecting data center)
 - A **human mistake** (employee accidentally deleting files)

👉 Easy Example:

- Just like a storm is a threat to a house, a phishing attack is a threat to a company's data.

2. Threat Actor

- A **threat actor** is the **person, group, or entity** that carries out (or has the capability to carry out) a threat.
- In cybersecurity, threat actors are **attackers**.

👉 Easy Example:

- If a **thief** breaks into a house → the **thief** = **threat actor**, the **robbery** = **threat**.

Types of Threat Actors & Their Motives

1. Cyber Criminals

- **Motive:** Financial gain (stealing money, credit card fraud, ransomware).
- **Example:** Hacker steals bank credentials to transfer money.

2. Hacktivists

- **Motive:** Political, social, or ideological cause.
- **Example:** Attacking a government website to protest against policies.

3. Nation-State Actors

- **Motive:** Cyber warfare, espionage, disrupting enemy nations.
- **Example:** State-sponsored hackers stealing military secrets.

4. Insider Threats

- **Motive:** Revenge, financial gain, carelessness.
- **Example:** Disgruntled employee leaks confidential data.

5. Script Kiddies

- **Motive:** Fun, challenge, bragging rights.
- **Example:** Beginner hacker using free tools to deface websites.

Summary Table

Threat Actor	Motive	Example
Cyber Criminals	Money (fraud, ransomware)	Bank fraud
Hacktivists	Political/social message	Website defacement
Nation-State Actors	Espionage, cyber warfare	Military data theft
Insider Threats	Revenge, greed, negligence	Employee leaks data
Script Kiddies	Fun, challenge	Random website hacks

👉 So, **Threat** = potential danger,
Threat Actor = who causes that danger,
Motive = why they do it.